OK 原本是个玩笑

The Joke That Became OK



一个拼写笑话，怎样变成了OK?

英文原文

OK, often said to be the planet's **most frequently** spoken word, began as a newspaper **gag**. From 1838 **abbreviations** were **all the vogue** in Boston's papers, and the **craze** turned **comic** through **deliberate misspellings**: O.W. for 'oll wright', K.Y. for 'know yuse'. The **humour lay in** the **persona** of an **uneducated bumpkin**.

On 23 March 1839 a Boston Morning Post **satire took a swipe at** a **contemporary**, the Providence Journal, over a **mock** society **parodying** an **ordinance** against ringing dinner bells. It carried the first known 'o.k.', **glossed as** 'all correct'. The letters **stood for** a **knowingly illiterate** 'oll korrect'. The **presumed** writer was the **editor**, Charles Gordon Greene.

Partisan politics **propagated** the letters nationwide. In 1840 Martin Van Buren, the **incumbent** president, sought **re-election**. His New York **backers**, **punning on** his nickname 'Old Kinderhook', after his **birthplace**, formed the Democratic O.K. Club, making the letters a **double-meaning slogan**. That November William Henry Harrison **unseated** him, 234 **electoral votes** to 60.

On 30 March 1840 the New York Morning Herald printed a **fabricated smear**: the former president Andrew Jackson, a **supposedly inept** speller, had marked **paperwork** O.K., for 'Ole Kurrek'. Jackson spelled **reasonably** well and never marked documents O.K. Within about twenty years, people did so **in earnest**. The **bogus notation** was merely **premature**.

Rival stories offered **exotic pedigrees**: Choctaw 'okeh' and Greek 'ola kala'. **Authoritative** dictionaries favoured Choctaw as late as 1961. In 1963–64 the linguist Allen Walker Read **excavated** the **neglected** Boston **provenance** from **archival** newspapers in six **influential** American Speech articles. Most dictionaries now **embrace** his **derivation**, a **pedigree** of bad spelling and dinner-bell satire.

中文译文

OK，常被说成是全世界最常说出的词，起初只是报纸上的一个噱头。从1838年起，缩写风靡于波士顿各大报纸，而且这股狂热也变得滑稽起来，通过故意的错误拼写：用 O.W. 代表 'oll wright'，用 K.Y. 代表 'know yuse'。幽默在于一个没受过教育的乡巴佬人物角色。

1839年3月23日，《波士顿晨邮报》的一篇讽刺文章抨击了一个同时期的报纸《普罗维登斯日报》，话题是一个恶搞的社团，它戏仿一项禁止敲开饭铃的法令。它刊载了已知最早的“o.k.”，被注释为“all correct”（完全正确）。这两个字母代表的是有意写成文盲拼法的'oll korrect'。推定的作者是该报纸的编辑查尔斯·戈登·格林。

党派政治在全国宣传了这些字母。1840年，在任总统马丁·范布伦寻求连任。他在纽约的拥护者拿他的绰号 'Old Kinderhook' 玩双关，这个绰号得名于他的出生地，他们成立了民主党 O.K. 俱乐部，让这两个字母成了一句一语双关的口号。那年11月，威廉·亨利·哈里森把他赶下台，选举人票为234张对60张。

1840年3月30日，《纽约先驱晨报》刊登了一则捏造的抹黑：前总统安德鲁·杰克逊，一个据称拼写笨拙的人，曾在公文上标注 O.K.，用以代表“Ole Kurrek”。杰克逊拼写得还算/尚且不错，并且从没在文件上批注过 O.K.。在大约二十年内，人们就认真地这样做了。这个伪造的批注，不过是出现过早而已。

与之竞争的说法给出了种种异域的来历，比如乔克托语的 'okeh'和希腊语的 'ola kala'。权威词典直到1961年还倾向于乔克托语一说。1963至1964年，语言学家艾伦·沃克·里德从档案报纸中发掘出长期被忽视的波士顿起源，这些发现发表在《美国语言》杂志的六篇影响深远的文章里。如今大多数词典都采纳了他的词源解释，那是一段由错误拼写和开饭铃讽刺文构成的来历。

词汇与表达

most frequently adv.
最常

gag n.
噱头

abbreviations n.
缩写
From 1838 abbreviations were all the

all the vogue n.
风靡
1838 abbreviations were all the vogue

craze n.
狂热

comic adj.
滑稽

deliberate adj.
故意的
comic through deliberate misspellings:

misspellings n.
错误拼写
comic through deliberate misspellings:

humour n.
幽默

lay in phr.v.
在于
The humour lay in the persona of an

persona n.
人物角色
The humour lay in the persona of an

uneducated adj.
没受过教育的

bumpkin n.
乡巴佬

satire n.
讽刺文章
1839 a Boston Morning Post satire

took a swipe at idiom
抨击了
took a swipe at a contemporary, the

contemporary n.
同时期的

mock adj.
恶搞的

parodying v.
戏仿

ordinance n.
法令
an ordinance against ringing dinner

glossed as v.
被注释为
first known 'o.k.', glossed as 'all

stood for 表达
代表
The letters stood for a knowingly illiterate

knowingly adv.
有意

illiterate adj.
文盲

presumed adj.
推定的

editor n.
编辑

Partisan adj.
党派
Partisan politics propagated the

propagated v.
宣传了
Partisan politics propagated the

incumbent adj.
在任
Buren, the incumbent president, sought

词汇与表达（续）

re-election n.
连任

backers n.
拥护者

punning on phr.v.
拿……玩双关
His New York backers, punning on his

birthplace n.
出生地

double-meaning adj.
一语双关的

slogan n.
口号
the letters a double-meaning slogan.

unseated v.
把……赶下台

electoral votes adj.
选举人票

fabricated adj.
捏造的
Herald printed a fabricated smear:

smear n.
抹黑

supposedly adv.
据称

inept adj.
笨拙的
a supposedly inept speller, had marked

paperwork n.
公文

reasonably adv.
还算/尚且

in earnest phr.
认真地

bogus adj.
伪造的
The bogus notation was merely

notation n.
批注

premature adj.
过早
bogus notation was merely premature.

exotic adj.
异域的

pedigrees n.
来历

Authoritative adj.
权威
Authoritative dictionaries favoured

excavated v.
发掘

neglected adj.
忽视的

provenance n.
起源
the neglected Boston provenance from

archival adj.
档案

influential adj.
影响深远的

embrace v.
采纳了

derivation n.
词源
now embrace his derivation, a pedigree

pedigree n.
来历
his derivation, a pedigree of bad spelling and

文章简述

- 起点：1838年起，波士顿报纸流行故意拼错英语再缩写开玩笑。1839年出现已知最早的o.k.，取自all correct（完全正确）的错拼oll korrect。
- 竞选：1840年，范布伦阵营用他绰号Old Kinderhook的缩写OK拉票，兼指他本人和“完全正确”；他最终以60对234张选举人票败给哈里森，未能连任。
- 流传：OK继续流行。杰克逊用它批公文的传闻是捏造，但此后约二十年内，人们真开始这样批注。
- 旧说：乔克托语是美国原住民的一种语言，旧词源说认为OK来自其中表示“是的”的okeh，不少词典曾采纳。
- 考证：里德1963至1964年查旧报，找回波士顿早期用例；多数词典后来接受英语错拼缩写的解释，取代乔克托语词源说。